

RESPIRATORY SYSTEM

You take a breath 12–20 times per minute. The purpose of your breath is to get oxygen to your cells and to get rid of waste like carbon dioxide. The respiratory system includes the nasal cavities, air passageway tubes, and lungs.

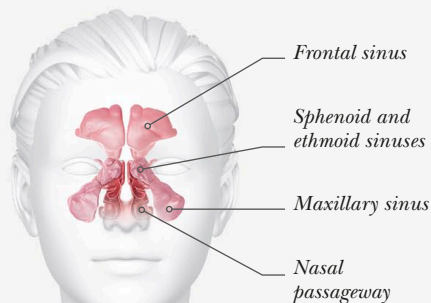
SYSTEM OVERVIEW

You don't have to think to breathe; respiration is a part of your autonomic nervous function. However, yogis claim that by controlling your breath, you can control all aspects of being. Science reveals that your breath is an access point to regulating your nervous system.



Neti pots

The neti pot is a part of traditional yogic hygiene practices. It involves pouring clean (filtered or boiled), warm salt water in one nostril to fill the sinuses and drain out the other nostril. Neti pots (or a similar sinus rinse) are recommended by many modern physicians to help allergies and respiratory illness.



SINUSES

Your sinuses are a system of connected, air-filled cavities in your skull. They make your skull lighter, help your voice to resonate, and affect your breath.

Nasal cavity
Air entering through nose is humidified, warmed, and filtered

Nostril
Openings in the nose

Mouth
Air can enter here, though less efficient

Epiglottis
Flap that closes off trachea to keep food from entering airways

Larynx
Top part of trachea, contains vocal cords

Trachea
Also called the windpipe, carries air to lungs

Lungs
Branching airways end here; oxygen enters blood and carbon dioxide is removed

Diaphragm
Primary muscle of respiration